

DROPFLEET
COMMANDER

DROPZONE
COMMANDER



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2316

THE LAST LANDLOCKED YEAR

Having mastered nuclear fusion in the late 22nd century, mankind ended 200 years of decline and resource conflict between the continental powers. Given limitless energy, geoengineering reversed Earth's climate collapse, though not its biodiversity. With the planet fully harnessed, war's technological advancements were turned to peaceful purposes by our first global government. The crowning achievement of this century of progress was the Foldspace Drive, a faster than light means of crossing interstellar distances.



2342

THE SHALTARI

Foldspace travel grows inaccurate with distance—reaching the next system presents a few light minute's error, but attempting a jump to another spiral arm invites emergence virtually anywhere. Leaving a foldspace node at the destination grants accuracy, so exploration requires near-random jumps or a creeping advance. Even modern drives can only make a few dozen jumps between major overhauls, so early expansion crawled. Colonies were established, but nothing approaching Earth's lost perfection was found.

Then, the Shaltari made contact—slight, spiny aliens, hyper-advanced and slow to reproduce, but they could transfer their consciousness into new bodies to effectively cheat death. Initially friendly, they bought an alliance by revealing seven Earth-like, uninhabited planets for mankind: the Cradle Worlds.

Sadly, it seemed that in us the Shaltari had identified a vigorous race they could use in their internecine wars. This was rejected, and the alliance collapsed.





2505

ZENITH

Freely settling the seven Cradle World systems unlocked riches. From glistening capitals to busy, colonial factories, decadence and achievement blossomed. Under mankind's centralised, democratic government—the Earth Administration Authority—even Earth was restored to beauty. A glorious peace beckoned.



2506

THE WHITE SPHERE

Investigating a micro-meteor which had landed in northern Peru, EAA scientists found a smooth, pearlescent, baseball-sized object denser than any known element.



As this White Sphere was touched by a networked probe, every computer in South America froze, releasing vast bandwidth. Seas of data flooded the research facility, and, it is assumed, the Sphere communicated with external parties, as it was quickly raided, and the Sphere removed.

Three days later, on 1st May, a message blanketed all channels on every human world: mankind should abandon Earth and the Cradle Worlds to follow mysterious guidance into uncharted space in exactly one year's time or face death at the hands of an unknown foe.

Fear and division grew. As the day neared, a tide of convinced souls stole or chartered a mishmash of ships. This 'Abandonist' armada amassed above Vega IV, the coordinates supplied by the White Sphere. Hoping to uphold order and curtail the exodus, the EAA sent Battlefleet Earth to intervene.

Once warned they would be fired upon if any ship spun up its Foldspace drive, the Abandonists shot first and together, initiating the infamous Battle of Vega. Although out-gunned ship-ship, the Abandonist's numbers and their audacious first strike freed most to jump away. Their faith in The Warning spared them the coming horrors and set them on a divergent path, but they had crippled humanity's premier battlefleet.





2507

INVASION

At 06:00hrs EST, 3rd May 2507, thousands of chillingly alien ships leapt out of Foldspace and blazed towards Earth. Foldspace drives cannot function near gravity wells, so it would take them eight hours under sublight to reach orbit. This grim countdown clawed at the inexperienced entrenched, gripping their weapons and prepping their vehicles.

The aliens annihilated the remains of Battlefleet Earth, sustaining minimal losses before making orbit. Earth's skies blackened with bizarre dropships—Earth's air defences were throwing pebbles at a hurricane. Nightmarish alien vehicles and bipedal, lizard-like beings landed and began scalding Earth's shocked defenders with plasma-based weaponry.

Within hours, ships filled with terrified refugees while screams, pleas, and static jammed the airways. Millions were crushed in stampedes and skirmishes for a ride off planet, and many ships fell to boarding actions before reaching a jump point—the enemy now seemed more concerned with capturing civilians than killing them.

Ships that could jump often chose mankind's backwater, isolated Colonies, but those that chose the Cradle Worlds found mirrored nightmares there. The fortunate jumped again, the rest were taken before their drives recharged.

Colonial governors who had yet to be attacked quickly ordered the recoding of their planet's Foldspace nodes, dooming those yet to escape. This likely saved the Colonies and those that fled to them, as surely the enemy would have soon discovered the node codes.

1% of Earth's and 5% the Cradle World's inhabitants escaped to the Colonies.



THE SCOURGE

The survivors had to reckon with their loss and their future; the Colonies were a far cry from the majesty of Earth or the Cradle Worlds. For the locals, their backwaters were now havens for millions. All awaited invasion with only scraps to fight with.

The enemy never came. Apparently, their ships couldn't simply jump to the Colonies' locations—something they must have discovered of by then—so they presumably required Foldspace nodes too, unlike the advanced Shaltari, so how had they struck so precisely?

The Colonies were rough, harsh, but resource-rich, and their hardened peoples rose to the new reality, knowing a far greater threat than their fellow humans.

They studied the true nature of the enemy—apparently carbon-based, vertebrates, lizard-like, and warm-blooded. However, aspects of their nervous system were chemically, biologically, and visually divergent. Accounts of other, unrelated species existed, from hulking juggernauts to sinuous, worm-things with razor limbs. Specimens were rare, but all showed that neurological discord.

The alien's constructs were all hideously organic-looking, sharing common design traits and engineering. Non-biological, but footage of destroyed examples often showed a tarry substance oozing from ruptures. Unsurprisingly, only fragments were available for study.

In time, a name emerged for the foe: The Scourge.



UNITED COLONIES OF MANKIND

Colonial resource wealth, the only reason they existed anyway, was leveraged. Cities sprouted, and unlike the opulent metropolises of Earth or the Cradle Worlds these were thriving, hasty melting pots. A multi-planet federation was established: The United Colonies of Mankind. Every surviving Colony joined except Kalium—distaining control from Aurum, the UCM's declared capital world, Kalium's government reconfigured its nodes, catapulting their rogue Colony into isolation.

Most assumed the enemy would eventually find and node an accurate route to the Colonies, so the UCM's mobilisation exceeded even the war-torn 22nd Century. Weapons were developed, and the largest navy in human history was laid down. After over one and a half centuries of driven growth, the UCM could finally contemplate vengeance.

Intelligence gathering inside the occupied systems began. Amazingly, human Foldspace nodes were still active inside all but one system. Void-based stealth nodes hadn't existed pre-invasion, so most space-borne types had long been destroyed, so ground nodes had been concealed and maintained.

Early missions uncovered resistance groups—their two centuries under Scourge occupation were invaluable intelligence. Shockingly, the enemy's foot-soldiers were now human. Confirming some scientist's fears, the aliens were gelatinous neuroparasites. Their host ceased aging, their span now tied to the life of the parasite itself—perhaps 2-3 centuries, as almost all the original lizard-like hosts were dead. These were those unfortunate humans assimilated during the invasion, although Scourge vehicles were piloted by host-less 'pure' Scourge bonded to their chassis amid a tarry suspension.

The Scourge usurped everything else too. Expecting ashes, recon teams found most industries still operating, if turned or augmented for the enemy. Even the vast orbital instillations, some of which had taken a century to build, were intact.

Everywhere, the enemy were constructing 'Seeds', small vessels dispatched to make blind Foldspace jumps to presumably seek fresh victims. The rewards and urgency of recapture had skyrocketed.



JUNE 5TH, 2670

THE POST HUMAN REPUBLIC

One and a half centuries' righteous hatred was poised to be unleashed. Thousands of mighty warships, countless armoured battalions, and the vast Colonial Legions readied for history's most titanic endeavour. June 6th was chosen, echoing an auspicious, ancient date.

Even this force couldn't invade eight fronts, so the element of surprise would be spent against Eden Prime, the most developed Cradle World. The High Council needed an early victory and Earth was nigh-impregnable, but it might be assailed once the Cradle World's resources were denied to the enemy and added to the UCM.

Amidst the Departure Ceremony on Aurum, an unknown vessel appeared at Aurum's outer marker. Its flowing hull contrasted sharply with its brutal weapon broadsides. Not Shaltari or Scourge, it resembled human ships but was more refined than anything the UCMF had. It hailed the High Council, with the necessary codes, and soon a delegation descended.

The unsettling, overly perfect delegates declared themselves representatives of the Post Human Republic, descendants of those who had followed the White Sphere. They implored the Council not to attack, insisting they were ill-prepared. This, coupled with their superior serenity, did not sit well. The UCM hadn't forgotten the Abandonist's treachery. Leaving murmurs in their wake, the delegation departed.

A new player at this hour was unwelcome, but this mysterious culture would have a part to play, perhaps a crucial one, for all of mankind.



JUNE 6TH, 2670 –
FEBRUARY 10TH, 2671

RECONQUEST PHASE 1

A deluge of burning wreckage from stricken ships heralded D-Day for Eden Prime's resistance, with no way to tell friend from foe. All they could do was dig in, struggle to keep their breakfasts down, and pray for the UCM's fleet.

Extensive intel, surprise, and massive numerical superiority ensured the annihilation of the Scourge garrison fleet. Next, a limited, precise bombardment opened, targeting those few areas that were entirely Scourge dominated and expendable; far better to capture assets than master a ruin.

Nine hours after the UCM fleet entered the system, the first of four hundred strike carriers broke atmo. Each carried 120 dropships, 300 vehicles, a fighter squadron, and a full cohort of 1000 Legionnaires. Bulk landers followed until seven legions and five armoured corps were committed to the capital, New Troy—by D-day's end, a drop of eight million men. An estimated 75 million human beings took part in some way on that day.



Estimated casualty figures for D-day at New Troy alone stood at 400,000 wounded and 350,000 killed—exceeding projections, but acceptable. Naval losses passed 90,000 sailors. Resistance casualties were unknown but modest; their main job, reconnaissance and sabotage, had been conducted prior. After this bloodiest day in 163 years, D-Day was declared a success, but most of Eden Prime remained to conquer.

On November 29th, 2670, the UCM invaded Elysium Prime, the most productive agri-planet known. Five million combat troops were deemed sufficient. The victory would be slower, but the UCM couldn't spare more. The Scourge were routed in orbit, but Battlefleet Elysium suffered raids by Shaltari pirates, that race's first obvious involvement, motives unknown. They struck inexplicably, if rarely, in multiple theatres, disrupting UCM and Scourge operations.

On February 1st, 2671, the UCMF was unleashed against Olympus Prime, once humanity's factory-world and its premier shipyard. There, a Scourge armada had assembled. The fight to cripple it was projected to last 48 hours, but by February 10th, the UCMF had lost 124 capital ships including 32 battleships and 3 dreadnoughts. Enemy reinforcement waves suffered

in kind, but the invasion of Olympus Prime was postponed due to clouds of spinning debris. Some denounced this, the First Battle of Olympus, as a pyrrhic victory, and a PHR fleet had punched right through the battle to land a small ground force before the debris forced their ships to withdraw.

On February 5th, the UCM invaded the Shangri-La system, once famed for its beauty, tourism, and mineral resources. Jungle-covered and without the metropolises of other Cradle Worlds, the invasion concerned the capture of Shangri-La's many isolated spaceports. Void superiority was quickly achieved given the siphoning of Scourge ships to Olympus, and the UCM began landings.

The Cradle World of Aaru was still an intelligence-gathering operation. With most life confined underground within city-sized caverns, traditional approaches, such as

bombardment, were inoperable, and a Shaltari presence complicated matters.



At Asgard, the UCM had dispatched a clandestine force of 8000 elite troops to coordinate with that Cradle World's resistance. However, possibly influenced by PHR infiltrators, the expeditionary ships were destroyed, and the ground nodes disabled by the resistance. Foldspace comms require a ship at a jump point to open a limited rupture to transmit through. Isolated and with no naval presence, any distress calls from the surface would take millennia to reach the Colonies. The PHR had intervened frequently elsewhere too, vanishing once their mysterious objectives were presumably achieved.

The Tlalocan system, four verdant moons orbiting a gas giant, was the only Cradle World system without functioning nodes. However, a classified, man-portable Foldspace node was snuck aboard a PHR cruiser by a Colonial spy. Instead of exposing a PHR world, as intended, the cruiser had jumped to the Tlalocan Moons. A UCM stealth lighter jumped there, dropped a permanent stealth node, and observed a PHR

invasion involving over 200 capital ships, more than the Republic's entire Grand Fleet was previously reckoned to be. This remained classified, leaving the system officially inaccessible.

On Earth, recon confirmed enemy void presence reduced by losses at Olympus, but still extreme. Scourge exploitation and entrenchment there was unequalled—Earth had the greatest pre-war population and industrial base. Landmasses were rife with Seed production, nightmarish breeding hives, and formidable defences. The resistance was numerous, but any invasion was implausible.

Elsewhere in the Solar system, the only event of note was the loss of the Lysander class stealth lighter UCMS Azure Night near Callisto. These had generally been proof against all scanners, but the Night was apparently intercepted and destroyed with all hands by a cruiser-sized vessel of non-Scourge origin, likely Shaltari. After, recon patrols avoided the moon, given its low strategic value.



**FEBRUARY 11TH, 2671 –
OCTOBER 19TH, 2671**

RECONQUEST PHASE 2

Battlefleet Eden remained harried by Shaltari raiders, holding extra ships in-system. Eden Prime's cities were in Colonial hands except frozen Atlantia and New Athens—Scourge-riddled graves for two million UCM enlisted—and the arid sprawl of Star Casablanca. The latter was encircled, containing massive Scourge armour swarms. AHQ lobbied the High Council to suspend their 'preserved city' policy and nuke it to avoid projected losses in street fighting, where Scourge grav-tanks excelled. Meanwhile, the UCMA advanced into Atlantia, den of the feral warlord Salakahn, irritant to the UCM and ally of convenience to the PHR. When the Maganum 2nd Legion and two armoured corps overran the city on June 30th, Salakahn detonated several strategic warheads, annihilating it and one million Colonial soldiers. Small comfort that he'd vaporised his erstwhile allies and the Scourge.

The fighting on Elysium Prime ground on. The primary objective had been achieved early with the destruction of the Scourge fleet: denying them Elysium's agricultural bounty. The original deployment of 5 million weary troops, now down to 72% combat effectiveness, would have to suffice.

On Shangri-La, the cleansing of a thousand jungle redoubts and spaceports continued. On October 9th, Battlefleet Shangri-La began a system-wide sweep to mop up Scourge guerilla battlegroups. Spread thin and out of battleline, they were unprepared for the massive PHR fleet that jumped in, broke through, and began landings in obscure locations, clearing them of UCM and Scourge alike. By October 19th the PHR remained in system, actively avoiding decisive battle.

Olympus Prime was the grave of a thousand vessels. Debris made landings dangerous to all but Strike Carriers. Since most ships had been destroyed at combat speed (gravity-nulled





below orbital velocity), these would burn up eventually. Debris and enemy control of the low-orbit defence grid precluded bombardment, so the UCMF blockade began expeditionary landings. PHR presence inside the capital, Asphodel, complicated matters, but they would be trapped until the debris cleared.

On Aaru, the UCM sponsored a resistance guerrilla campaign, but it operated without heavy support, and bombardment was not competent against this cavern world. The Shaltari continued to battle the Scourge there, as they had fought humanity for Aaru in the pre-war days. Though this Cradle World had apparent significance for the aliens, it was graded low priority by AHQ.

Asgard remained inaccessible, and its UCM expeditionary force stranded. Colonel Hellburn did get a message out to the Colonies via an antique civilian yacht—he still had 5000 men and would withdraw to the swamps north of Odinsburg. From there, he would attempt to find and re-activate a surface node.

The Tlalocan Moons remained under surveillance by Marine Force Black (MFB). The PHR's invasion neared completion, and they were constructing military complexes and orbitals. This remained classified due to a growing suspicion that a PHR spy operated inside the High Council. President Belaque and her overstretched military chiefs decided to accept Republic control of the system for the present.

Earth remained a grim fortress. However, much had left to bolster Scourge forces elsewhere, and those ships sent to Olympus Prime were now debris. The High Council decided an offensive action in the Solar system would boost morale—millions of body-bags and MIA notes had come home already. Jupiter's moon, Europa, was encrusted in sterile H₂O—a requirement for 'Pure' Scourge construct pilots. A plan to deny them this massive source was conceived.



In 164 years, the Scourge had never communicated—until one hailed the High Council. Its albino-red eyes regarded the chamber from a cold screen. Sweat licked its pallid flesh. Facial tics hinted at inner turmoil—perhaps against the driven insane, captive mind of its host—but what radiated from that expression was hate. Behind him, it, a yellow planet loomed.

It still hadn't spoken. Three more Councillors cannoned in, one stumbling on seeing the screen. Another squeezed President Belaque's shoulder on his way past—Wolfrum's Jonas Crowe. Someone she could trust in a crisis. He hadn't spilt his coffee. Lieutenant Dawkins spoke via intercom, "The rest are thirty minutes out, Madam President."

"OK, Lieutenant. Seal the chamber. This stays in here for now."

"Yes, ma'am. Secluding now."

The doors slammed. Chilling silence reigned. The Scourge opened with a cracked, mocking chuckle.

"Encouraging, that you would converse with us."

The President swallowed. "Do you have a name?"

"Names are for the selfish and for pets, President Helena Alma Belaque."

"If you wish this discussion to continue, you'll show me some damned respect."

"This one apologises," said the creature. "The notion of a feeble, isolated mind representing your entire species is... quaint. You do this on purpose? Interesting... The self of an individual with... power... over the many, but this one digresses. We are not here for ruminations over our obvious differences. We are bending to this necessity to convey truths. You will listen?"

"Yes," said the President. "For whatever these 'truths' may be worth, we shall hear them."

"Good. Our species have been labouring under a delusion: that this war is ours. All have been manipulated and shepherded into this by others without regard for any but themselves. Even you can understand what this one speaks of?"

Councillor Muller watched his clenched fingers. "The Republic?"

The Scourge laughed. "The new things? This has been in the making far longer than they have existed. Their presence has... complicated. No."

The President shifted in her chair. "Shaltari".

"Yesssss," it hissed, fixated on her. "You understand. They have worked for centuries to engineer this. They seeded worlds with your virulence, and after your numbers had bloated, they laid you before us. Subtle redirection... Such perfect hosts, so prolific. It was simple, infiltrating your ignorant systems. Instinct. We did not ask who was serving to us. Unfortunate, for the Shaltari, that you proved too feeble. That Sphere curio had a hand in that. Since, the Shaltari have stymied our efforts to find you—the hosts left before dessert. You have gratified them with this 'Reconquest'. They have been intervening, preventing decisive endings while we are each numerous. Their goal is slow death by war for both our species."

A thought steeled President Belaque. It thinks they will win. "This changes little. Your enslavement of billions will be answered. If the Shaltari did this, we shall exterminate them once we're done with you. Ad Vindictam. For Vengeance."

"SILENCE! This one's race offers terms so we may end the Shaltari unencumbered by you. You will withdraw from all save Eden and Elysium, which you may keep in our largess. You will cease void operations against us. Then, we may permit you existence."

The President sat straighter. "We will not."

The parasite's reply was smooth as a killer's blade, "Failure to comply will have immediate consequences. Decide."

The President addressed the comms office, "Dawkins, pause our feed, please," and turned to her colleagues. "Well?" She allowed them a moment's blustering indignation, given the circumstances. "Enough! I take it nothing this bastard offers will do, short of them all eating grenades? Indeed. They're not as assured as they pretend. Why even ask? We're hurting them. Let's continue to do so?" President Belaque returned firm nods and a few grim smiles. "Dawkins, restore, please." She addressed the nightmare staring down at them, "We will not rest until you are expunged. However, you will die assured that the spiny little cheats will be next."

The Scourge smiled. "So be it. The personal is distasteful to us, but I admit to... satisfaction, with you. You do not disappoint. Neither shall we." An alert light pulsed on the President's desk. Someone banged on the chamber's locked door. "This, human, is the Shaltari's third attempt to throw another species into our path. We are still here. Soon you will not be, save those we keep." The screen died.

Councillor Paige slammed the door unlock button and Dawkins stumbled in. "It's... Ferrum. Where the hail came from... matches... modulation delay patterns. We're under attack."

Later -

The High Councillor had cultivated the affectation of moonlighting up here, on the roof, the last few years. Time to reflect before the President's speech. Damn, it'd better be a good one. This would help her. His handlers had assured him it would. He thought-woke his implanted neurocomm and gazed at the metropolis, uploading his recent memories to the circling presence above.

"Will it change their course?" asked a disembodied voice.

"I doubt it," thought the Councillor.

"Expected," said the voice. "We must accelerate operations. The clock ticks, Agent. We stand between sentient life and annihilation".

"Perhaps time to tell them that?"

An uncharacteristic pause. "No. You heard. The hate. The single-mindedness. And the Republic was the first enemy suspected. Nurture that focused hatred. It serves its purpose. They have their enemy. It will strengthen them for when they come. Return to the President. Assist. You continue to perform excellently. Humanity, both enlightened and unenlightened, will remember this one day."

With weary conviction, he descended to rejoin the panic.



OCTOBER 21ST, 2671 –
MAY 7TH, 2672

COUNTEROFFENSIVE

Ferrum's defenders had just nine hours as the Scourge armada burned in from its outer marker, but mankind knew its enemy now, and Ferrum was militarised. How the Scourge had cracked Colonial nodes or planted their own remains unknown. Outnumbered and running cold, Ferrum's outer patrols died in high velocity void actions. Once the enemy slowed to orbital combat speed, the bulk of Battlefleet Ferrum could engage, sacrificing itself to slow the onslaught. Defence batteries blazed while other Colonies rushed in reinforcements. The fastest reached orbit within seven hours, savaging the enemy's second wave.

Four million Scourge made planetfall before the first nukes detonated. Whether desperation or usual Scourge tactics against a planet they didn't care to take, this was new—surface delivery was the only viable method against a planet with a comprehensive missile halo.

Fighting raged around the Ferrous Motors gigafactory, where tanks raced off the line into the fray unpainted. The Admiralty sent ships from wherever it could. Finally, by the second month, the UCMF regained the void. The stranded Scourge sold their lives savagely. No prisoners were assimilated – their rotting bodies were dumped by dropships into population centres. A billion civilians died, dwarfing the military's entire Reconquest losses. By early May, 2672, and at appalling cost, Colonial will to fight at home had been demonstrated.

On November 29th, 2671, the ocean Colony of Alumina was attacked. Possibly, Scourge Seeds had discovered several Colonies, perhaps diverted by Shaltari desiring an equilibrium of slaughter. Whatever the cause, Alumina's naval picket fell in hopeless defiance. It was not greatly militarised, being a global fishery, but 60% of the UCM's protein came from Alumina. Scourge bulk landers soon dumped liquids into those teeming waters, and putrefying fish soon formed nation-sized rafts. A UCMF relief fleet battered the retreating enemy, but the desecration was done.

On January 25th, 2672, Wolfrum was attacked. A penal backwater, rivers of molten metal and chemical lakes made it lethally profitable. Productive convicts could earn the option to enlist to receive pardons. The Scourge soon breached its sulphurous, lightly defended atmosphere. The UCMF relief fleet was authorised to freely destroy enemy ships—collateral damage from shipfalls would be acceptable here. Regardless, Wolfrum's denizens bled the Scourge for every inch of ashen ground. Half died before the parasites were exterminated. Wolfrum was neither strategic nor populous, so perhaps the UCM's core planets, Aurum and Nicollum, remained inaccessible to the Scourge.



OCTOBER 20TH, 2671 –
MAY 7TH, 2672

RECONQUEST PHASE 3

The UCM's first offensive in the Solar system launched on November 1st. The Scourge H2O extractors on Europa were soft targets, and a strike in the home system was critical to restore morale. Taskforce Europa's raid obliterated all six facilities but suffered 80% casualties. A mighty cenotaph was built in Freedom Square, Aurum City, to join the others. On Earth, still considered unassailable, the UCM deserter Lt. Colonel Rodriguez began coordinating resistance factions around New York. Two MF-R teams were dispatched to apprehend him, but one failed and the other joined him. Whatever was happening around NCY was not UCM policy.

With one nuclear strike against Star Cassabanca, the last Scourge threat on Eden Prime was vaporised, and with the apparent death of Salakahn at the hands of allied resistance leader Karl Foley, the ferals were broken. The system was declared conquered on January 1st, 2672, and the UCMA raised its first Cradle World Legion. Exclusively ex-resistance, the Eden 1st was a veteran outfit from the outset, with Foley accepting command.

On Elysium, the Scourge encircled within the capital staged a breakout on October 31st. Triticum Plains was, by that point, the Reconquest's largest tank battle. The fatigued legions might have been overrun without Battlefleet Elysium's masterful combat bombardment. But then, the largest Shaltari fleet yet to engage the UCMF broke that bombardment, and twelve Armoured Corps and 700,000 legionnaires perished before the Scourge were routed. Elysium Prime was finally declared conquered on January 20th, 2672.

At Shangri-La, the PHR were withdrawing, so the UCM focused on the Scourge until reinforcements passing a PHR dropsite vanished, including three packed troopships—75,000 Legionnaires. The Grand Fleet's claims of innocence were ignored. The legions demanded blood, and it would be up to the UCMF to give it to them. The Admiralty's ultimatum that the Republic quit the system was dismissed, and PHR Grand Director Octavia Rhee defensively reformed her fleet. High Admiral Stern drove his force into them on November 12th in the largest UCM-PHR engagement to date and the example of how not to counter PHR naval tactics. Stern exposed his vanguard to double-broadsides, suffering grievously, although the UCMF's numbers told, and Rhee went down with her ship—a pyrrhic victory costing 35 capital ships, 45,000 lives and Stern's commission.

On the ground, the stranded PHR conducted a masterful jungle warfare campaign under Aurellia Felix, completing whatever mission they'd had while repelling UCM reprisals. She took prisoners, enough to honourably broker a ceasefire and her command's extraction. On May 1st, 2672, the High Council declared Shangri-La conquered despite Scourge guerrilla activity.

On Aaru, a Shaltari coalition, apparently led by the Mongol tribe, had invaded. Since Scourge ships had been siphoned off to fight elsewhere, the Shaltari gained void supremacy by early



May. That Aaru had special significance to the Shaltari was beyond doubt now, and it became a distant prospect for the overstretched UCM.

No news came from Colonel Hellburn's stranded force on Asgard, and intel from the Tlalocan moons confirmed a PHR conquest and entrenchment there. The UCM's Tlalocan stealth node remained classified, so both systems were officially inaccessible. ONI's operatives there did make a significant discovery: following a short-transmit, single-burst node inveigled aboard a PHR cruiser, a UCM Lysander translated into nothingness outside the Milky Way. Traces of a second jump remained. One jump easily encompasses this galaxy, so the PHR's 'home soil' may be in another. It would take fifty jumps to reach the nearest—triple the service life of a UCM Foldspace drive. Why and how they would have settled so far away was unknown, but most thought this explanation enough for the Republic's conquest of the Tlalocan Moons—they needed a forward base.

At Olympus, costly insertions on orbitals and defence grid stations were conducted by strike carrier due to lingering debris. Below, the stranded PHR still battled in the capital for six apparently worthless sectors. D-Day was delayed until August for optimal weather, allowing for a massive buildup. With Shaltari incursions, rising Scourge naval raids, and defences unrivalled by all but Earth, epic slaughter was brewing.

**MAY 8TH, 2672 -
JULY 24TH, 2672**

OPPORTUNITY

Recon patrols in the Solar system reported unusual Scourge shipping activity—groups were forming taskforces and jumping away. Not unheard of, but leavers had always been sighted reinforcing elsewhere. By June, 40% of Earth's garrison had vanished, and Admiralty hawks whispered of invasion. However, 60% of the largest fleet in known space remained.

On June 16th, an MF-R recon flight over North America's east coast detected a radiation surge. Their stealth lighter, Hope's Spark, confirmed a 30-megaton detonation. Philadelphia, the largest Scourge conurbation on the planet, was gone. Then, 37 smaller, low-ionisation atomics glassed other Scourge instillations around the eastern seaboard. Stunned analysts traced them to surface-based launchers.

The Spark's remaining MF-R teams deployed. With low wind and heavy rainfall, fallout was minimal. One detected a reactivated transponder signal from AWOL Lt Colonel Rodriguez: Liberty Island, within sight of hugely infested Manhattan. After dark, the team inserted along the Hudson at nought feet, lights off. Their tense encounter with the deserter and his resistance allies confirmed they'd identified the Scourge's missile halo control nexus, snuck in a high-yield warhead, detonated it, then nuked multiple defence instillations while the halo was down. Hope's Spark raced to a jump point to alert the Office of Naval Intelligence that Earth's defences were critically weakened.

After a week's frantic debate, the High Council wanted action while AHQ and the Admiralty projected casualties into the millions with a 27% victory probability. But the enemy were rebuilding—the grid over North America might be 90% re-harmonised by mid-February.





**JULY 25TH, 2672 –
SEPTEMBER 4TH, 2672**

TRIUMVIRATE

On July 25th, 2672, a strange flotilla translated near Aurum—pre-war classes, uniform, with unfamiliar insignia. On a regular military channel they declared themselves representatives of Kalium, the rogue colony. They were aware of the developments on Earth and proposed a joint invasion. Kalium's military dictatorship was distasteful, and an alliance would recognise an independent colony, but Kalium's Kabal would commit 180 capital ships, associated escorts, and thirteen legions—impressive after 165 years' isolation.

The PHR made quiet overtures too, but even Kalium was an easier pill to swallow. Despite tacit espionage, Kalium hadn't killed Colonials. Once Aurelia Felix was announced as the PHR's military attaché, things improved. On Shangri-La, her conduct had impressed. She made a compelling case for wanting their shared home planet liberated, and the PHR had few conditions save that their landing zones should be theirs alone until victory. Typically, their targets didn't always make strategic sense, and many fumed at their revealed occupation of the Tlalocan Moons, but since the UCM had no official presence there some conceded they'd rather see them in human hands.

The mood solidified once the projections came back. The UCM would be the senior partner, but with Kalium's help, the victory likelihood rose from 27% to 44%. Adding the Republic's advanced forces raised this to 72%. A conditional period of cooperation for invasion purposes was agreed, fraught with compromise—the Triumvirate Accord was signed.

SEPTEMBER 5TH, 2672 –
OCTOBER 1ST, 2672

BOLERO

A secret buildup plan was agreed, codenamed 'Operation Bolero'. D-Day was set for October 2nd, 2672—less than a month to prepare. A UCM invasion fleet was already massing at Olympus, so they simply added to it. Drills and patrols were arranged everywhere, ensuring high readiness.

Colonial observers at Kalium, shadowed by 'minders', were shocked at the Kabal's domination, but were forced to respect the results. Estimates placed Kalium's military power at 1/6th of the UCM's, despite technological inferiority. Of Kalium's three billion souls, 240 million were in uniform—8% mobilisation vs the UCM's 5.2%. Staged conscript parades demonstrated a clinical perfection that no Colonial Legion could equal, while columns of shiny, antiquated tanks trundled by. As for their fleet, serried ranks of warships were aligned in unnecessary, impressive synchrony.

The PHR furnished the other signatories with succinct progress reports, but the UCM's secret MF-B observers at Tlalocan had front-row seats to the Republic's muster. The Grand Fleet apparently deserved the name—over 300 capital ships had readied.

On Earth, pathfinders worked quietly to coordinate, equip, and urge the resistance to begin partisan campaigns. Sensing the time had come to use them, antique assets were dusted off, fuelled, and armed. Triumvirate fleets launched feints, and over Olympus Prime, the UCMF opened a massive bombardment. The Scourge siphoned more ships from Earth, and even braved Olympus Prime's recaptured defence grid to land four million more troops.

By D-1, history's largest concentration of might was ready: 1000 capital ships + escorts, 34 Colonial Legions and 19 armoured corps, 13 Kalium Legions, and millions of post-humans. When the UCM had invaded Eden Prime, 75 million had taken part on D-day. This would approach 320 million. Sealed orders were opened with amazement, awe, and terror, but the dreaded post-humans would be with them, along with forgotten Kalium.





OCTOBER 2ND, 2672

BATTLE FOR EARTH, D-DAY

Immediately, disaster struck—the UCMF's Shangri-La and Elysium musters hadn't jumped. Shaltari taskforces had translated beside the musters and attacked. Worse, some emanated gavitic waves, preventing jumps. 80% strength was already in play, so Grand Admiral Halsey re-directed taskforces from other Solar system targets to achieve full strength over Earth.

On the nine-hour approach, unprepared Scourge pickets were swept aside. Once in orbit over 'the hole' created by the resistance, defence fire was intense but uncoordinated, and scattered Scourge formations ploughed into Triumvirate armadas. Kalium's fleet suffered most, having insisted on being in the vanguard. The PHR's overlapping fields of fire helped, but all got pummelled.

Having learned from Olympus, deployment commenced before debris snowballed, despite the partially active grid. Hundreds of troopships and two thousand strike carriers descended. By midnight, half the Legions had made planetfall—thirty million soldiers, 55% within North America. Those that had to run a fully operational grid received additional fleet screening, but three million died on approach. The resistance rose. Scourge around the dropsites were exterminated and beachheads established, but one hundred million Scourge warriors were on Earth.

Earth's skies were an impossible tapestry of duelling voidcraft. Wrecks fell like stately meteors. Cities died. Scourge garrison ships fought viciously, but rather than charge in as expected, those further afield scattered. Before the Triumvirate could establish a blockade, most jumped away.



OCTOBER 3RD-8TH, 2672

BATTLE FOR EARTH, WEEK 1

On D+1, ten-million more Triumvirate troops landed, but by day three, debris made Earth impenetrable to all but Strike Carriers with minimal capacity compared to Troopships.

Over Shangri-La and Elysium, the trapped Colonials grappled to eliminate the Shaltari 'Anchors'. Outnumbered 5:1, the aliens never committed to a fair fight. Once the last 'Anchor' was burning, five days later, the rest fled. Finally freed, the battle-weary survivors jumped to Earth to find the Shaltari already there, sowing confusion and locking up shipping in anti-piracy patrols.

Orbital supremacy was achieved, but the grid remained in Scourge hands and 70% effective. 'The Hole' provided a 'safe' orbital refuge where the de-harmonised guns could be eliminated piecemeal. Elsewhere, the Triumvirate began Strike Carrier insertions to wrest control of the grid.

Below, the Triumvirate's staging zones and prefab bases were clear of major cities, where defences were lighter. Bulk landers aren't surface assets, and when combatants number in the millions, few can use dropships. Advance would be ponderous.



**OCTOBER 9TH -
NOVEMBER 2ND, 2672**

BATTLE FOR EARTH, MONTH 1

As expected, orbital debris told. Shielded from bombardment, the Scourge could manoeuvre while surface battles raged. At the Battle of Michigan, while the Kalium 2nd and 3rd Legions mustered in the arid lakebed, the Scourge erupted from Chicago. Three day's carnage claimed a million conscripts before victory. After, Colonial spies reported cargos of alien materiel being lifted off planet, but for solidarity's sake the UCM kept silent.

Orbital scans and terse PHR dispatches confirmed they had fortified their dropsites. Drawing the Scourge to them was strategically prudent, given the post-human's legendary toughness. Incidents of PHR attacking stray allies near their redoubts did occur, but some friendly fire was inevitable.

The UCMA trundled towards New York, Rio, Hong Kong, London, and a hundred other cities.

NOVEMBER 1ST –
DECEMBER 31ST, 2672

COUNTERPUNCH

First came a sharp increase in Scourge raids by former vessels of Earth's garrison. Earth's grid was 35% destroyed and 20% captured, within tolerance, so the UCMF and Grand Fleet dispersed to open bombardments against Mars, Titan, Ganymede, and Callisto.

Surface assaults on Earth's mega-cities began. Debris still prevented proper orbital assistance, and although it was clearing, mankind was ten Legions short of intended ground strength. The resistance harried the Scourge rear and provided crucial intel, but other, savage warlords killed all interlopers. Casualties mounted, and President Belaque controversially authorised conscription.

Then, on December 15th, a Scourge armada, twice the size of any human formation now, jumped in. When this sledgehammer achieved Earth orbit, it outnumbered the defenders 2:1. Losses were horrendous before garrisons from conquered Cradle Worlds and the Colonies rushed into the grinder. Kalium had nothing more to give. When the UCMF's line buckled, the PHR rose from their defensive stations and unleashed hell, driving the Scourge back. After a further two day's slaughter though, the Scourge's superior grid control began to tell. Then came a stroke of luck, or fate. A fleet appeared—large, human, and impossible.

December 24th, 2672, 11:05am, Supercarrier UCMS Shield of Aurum, Earth Orbit

As Grand Admiral Halsey limped onto his backup CIC, its holo-screens and Master View lit. The mystery fleet was close, but first: "XO, damage report."

"Weapons at 80%, drives 70%. Scanners 60%. Keel launch bays venting, multiple fires, and magazine detonations. We're down to 50% launch capacity. Not like we've got the aircraft to fill us anymore."

"Thanks, Yuri. Fire could spread to the ventral cores if we don't- "

"Sir, we're being hailed! Our, um, unexpected guests."

"Right. Patch it though."

A grimy, unshaven face filled the screen to Halsey's left. Not even in uniform, he looked like a greasy deck-chief. "Who the hell are you?" asked Halsey.

"Engineer Manfred Kramer, commanding the battleship EAAS Olympus, formerly of the EAA Grand Fleet. Reckon I represent us. You guys call us as the Vega Scrapfleet, I guess. We've been watching this shindig. Figure you could use us."

It'd been in a recent intel gist—just another collection of stranded survivors, this time cobbled together from the hulks of the infamous Battle of Vega, way back in 2507. A big group, apparently, but this? They'd contacted the Admiralty a month ago, and he'd written them off. Better swallow that. "Sir," said Halsey, "you are most welcome. This thing could go either way. If you could come in on the right flank, we could – "

"We'll come in where we want, Grand Admiral. But yes, I see the gap. We'll plug it."



Their ships were salvaged antiques, but their crews had survived generations of hardship alone and forgotten in the void. Their tenacious skill bolstered the human battleline.

On Christmas day, a near-suicidal charge from seven Kalium battleships penetrated the Scourge lines, allowing their missile cruisers to flow in and let loose. The hole was widened by the PHR until the Scourge fragmented, allowing the UCMF and Scrapfleet to engage piecemeal. On the 26th, the Scourge began a fighting withdrawal. The battered victors had lasted the bloodiest naval battle in history and the decisive battle for Earth's voidspace.

During the weary celebrations and amidst the electromagnetic storm of a thousand burning wrecks, no one noticed the faint pulses from the PHR's dropsites bellow.



2673 – BATTLE FOR EARTH, YEAR 1

The debris from the First Void Battle had partially cleared, and the Second had been fought in high orbit. The debris cascade would take a few weeks to block low orbit—a window to land more troops which the Triumvirate did not waste—but elsewhere in the Solar System, the Shaltari's intervention on D-day had cost the element of surprise. The early capture of the moon's grid control nexus, its Helium-3 mines, and Tranquillity, its lone city, was a rare success.

On the former penal colony of Mars, the Scourge had completed mankind's attempt to terraform it, although its red sands echoed its original appearance, from orbit anyway. Swathes of non-Earth origin flora and hordes of alien fauna ran rampant—wild populations of the Scourge's most vicious host species. Knowing this, the UCMF began an unrestricted bombardment of its missile halo stations with a view to ultimately glassing the corrupted planet from orbit with nukes.



Titan was bombarded conventionally late in 2673, pummelling Scourge industries there to rubble. In orbit there was Foundry Prime, the largest pre-war space station. The land-sized, high-tech battle to recapture it became the stuff of Colonial recruitment reels, although it wasn't strategically vital.

Ganymede, the system's largest moon, was the Scourge's remaining primary source of sterile H₂O, required by 'pure' Scourge. A blockade had quickly denied this to the enemy, then pulverised its substantial fleet garrison. Later that year, acting solely on their own initiative, the UCM sent three cohorts of Praetorian special forces into the enemy's unmapped H₂O mines. The Scourge had used pre-existing, mile-deep, and curiously cylindrical fissures to jumpstart their excavations, delving a further three miles down into the moon's subsurface ocean. Having exterminated the Scourge workers, the Praetorians planted their nukes, withdrew, and triggered a catastrophic collapse. Crushed by billions of tons of irradiated slush, the Scourge facility apparently emitted a death scream that washed comms in a flash of static throughout the system.

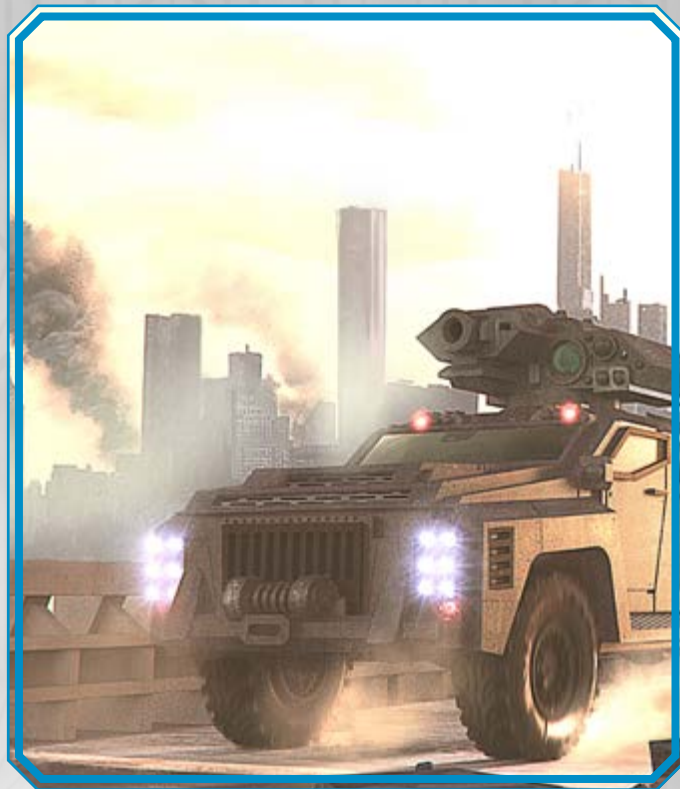
Fragmentary records indicated some unusual sub-surface anomalies and small, pre-war mines on Callisto, but nothing worth serious attention. The disappearance of there of the UCMF stealth Lysander Azure Night back in 2671 had, by this point, been largely forgotten. Despite this, the PHR insisted on its early capture to establish a base around Jupiter. The Republic conquered its surface by February and spent the rest of the year fortifying it while apparently digging out sub-surface pockets of Scourge miners.

On Earth itself, 2673 was a maelstrom of battle, with debris-limited fleet assistance. Fighting raged from ultra-dense urban icons to the endless industrial zones turned and augmented by the enemy.

In South America, attacks on its cities commenced early due to massive landings afforded by 'the hole'. In Rio, a PHR-led effort seized it in three months, supported by Kalium's assault against the city's Scourge breeding hives and host growing gigafactories. Kalium's Kabal was keen to decimate such horrors, although ONI kept watch on what the rogue colony discovered and especially what it lifted off-planet.

Lima's 'Caldera' was the largest subterranean stockpile of pre-war military hardware anywhere in the galaxy and the perfect target for the Scrapfleet, desperate for antique parts and replacements. Since the Scourge struggle to communicate underground, they had simply collapsed the Caldera's entrances long ago. In December, when the Scrapfleet's forces blasted their way in alongside the Titania 8th, they uncovered a bounteous tomb.

In Europe, careful, bloody battles for the small, historic centres of London, Paris, Rome, and Istanbul crept on, with only Berlin, Madrid, and Pisa entirely secured by year's end. In Moscow, the Kalium 11th pressed its successful landing there before winter, capturing 70% of the factory-city. From their command post in the dilapidated Kremlin, the 11th's officers directed a punishing winter campaign, ill-prepared given Kalium's climate and deaf to the UCMA's winter warfare specialists. By spring, most of the conscripts were thawing corpses, and the 11th spent the rest of the year holding on.



Asia's history as an ultra-populated centre for orbital construction unfortunately gave it the strongest grid coverage, rendering mass invasion untenable that year. Outside Tokyo though, UCM-Kalium infiltrators managed to get three tactical nukes inside a nightmarish mega breeding hive, decisively vaporising it and themselves to avoid capture. Hong Kong, small, dense, and likely a Scourge control hub, was a priority. The PHR, headed by a phalanx of heavy behemoths, dropped straight into Earth's tightest skyscraper forest, Hong Kong Island, while the UCMA's elite Anvils and Cuprum 1st enveloped Kowloon from the north. The ongoing destruction there slightly weakened Asia's grid, at great cost.

In Beijing, the Scourge had uniquely let seven million humans live 'free' inside towering mega-tenements. Sporadically, the enemy abducted thousands for assimilation—a likely experiment in 'wild farming', more economical than vat-growing hosts, and possibly abetted by the tenement's overlords. Thus, Beijing was only target in Asia to receive a full

wave-1 assault. Casualties on approach were brutal, but five million combat troops made it: the Titania 10th, Aurum 4th, and Stannum 1st, five Armoured Corps and the Kalium 8th, plus a PHR contingent which seized the naval bases of Tianjin. Despite early successes, scant reinforcements, grid strikes, and vicious counterattacks told. Within a month, a million Triumvirates were dead, with withdrawal impossible. Then, mid-year, revolutions within the tenements saw their ragged multitudes spill out to drive the Scourge back at enormous cost. A shaky bridgehead remained by December, bolstered by a relief corridor cleared by the UCMF's methodical operations to seize more of the grid.

In Africa, New Cairo was the gate to the argri-continent's north. The Titania 3rd and 4th, desert fighters, besieged it, hampered by Shaltari raids. To the far south, Aurelia Felix led the PHR's largest single army to crush Johannesburg. Rather than face months of urban attrition, she encircled it, left behemoths to pummel the Scourge, then raced north towards her unknown objectives. By year's end, her advance had diverged into a dozen tendrils, the furthest reaching the ruin of Nairobi. The UCMA's half of this continental pincer movement had barely moved.

In scorched, semi-abandoned Australia, the Triumvirate sponsored a guerrilla campaign by that continent's especially belligerent resistance—economical, and a supreme headache for the Scourge. The PHR launched some low-key incursions, but with battle raging in more critical theatres, Australia was a sideline.

In Antarctica, Amundsen was the objective—a conurbation of defence batteries and grid control stations. No resistance existed there, survival being impossible outside the city's biodomes. Rather than risk an orbital bombardment, a combined UCM-PHR-Kalium special ops team was landed in the uninhabited Falklands. From there, they travelled by rib boats to the Antarctic peninsula, traversed miles of icy tundra, and vanished in June's polar night.

Given the biblical scale of battle elsewhere, especially in North America, a follow-up operation was indefinitely postponed.

Washington DC, the Scourge's largest military hub, had survived the resistance's nuclear strike due to its stand-alone missile halo. Three legions and nine armoured corps had surrounded the city to bombard and contain the enemy. As the Scourge mustered at Richmond and Norfolk to affect a breakout, the Triumvirate enacted Operation Alesia—to face half their guns outwards and hold while the PHR launched disruptive raids on Richmond. Despite their efforts, the attack from Richmond was colossal, but ultimately broken due to Shaltari hampering of the Scourge's Norfolk muster. Millions of Scourge remained in DC.



Los Angeles, once the busiest metropolis on the continent, was reduced to a sandy, shattered graveyard after a year's brutal street fighting by Kalium's 5th and 7th legions. The PHR's expedition there distilled around Santa Monica, an abandoned residential zone, suffering minimal losses.

The shipyard metropolis of New Detroit was the second largest by area on Earth. Being a spaceport, the Scourge had reinforced it while they still had ships. For nine months, the UCM barely held its bridgehead, given the trickle of reinforcements due to debris. In the last months of 2673, once bulk landers could safely break atomo, their assault finally opened.

New York saw some of 2673's fiercest combat. There, four Colonial Legions with embedded subterranean warfare specialists from the Eden 1st were joined by three Armoured Corps. Additionally, the now infamous Kalium 13th assaulted Queens and Brooklyn. Unusually, the PHR's operations were interwoven with their allies, though they attended solely to Battery Park, Tribeca, and the Lower East Side. Repeatedly harried by Shaltari raids, the Triumvirate battered through the Scourge-riddled, ancient city. As planned, they converged at the Tartarus—a 1,800m Scourge edifice, the tallest building on the planet.





Prone, heart pounding, General Rawlins wormed herself further into her Phoenix Command Gunship's cupola. Through three inches of armoured plas-glass, smoke-wreathed Lower Manhattan passed below. A vicious firefight silhouetted the XIII'th Anvil's advancing behemoths while the acrid tang of plasma-scorched composite polluted her cramped space. She tried to temper the eagerness in her young, society-tuned voice. "Pilot, take us in."

"Ma'am." The gunship circled the pockmarked, ancient One World Trade Centre, bringing a towering affront into view: the Tartarus, aflame but still standing.

Rawlins flicked her commlink to orbital. "Fire mission. Fire mission. Cruiser Punisher?"

A gravelled voice crackled through static, "Confirmed: Tartarus halo is down. Weapon primed."

"Friendlies close. I shall paint target. Wait out."

"Ma'am."

Rawlins seized her control column with a clammy, manicured fist. "Pilot, I have control. All Triumvirate forces in quadrant nine—orbital strike. Brace. Brace." The Republic's deep scan of the Tartarus had indicated a structural flaw in the mile-high monstrosity—something to do with the bedrock, but whatever. Her grip tightened as a purple crack of ion-lightning seared the gunship's hull. "Almost..." Ravaged skyscrapers and Corsair interceptors whipped past. "FIRE!"

She hurled the gunship left. A vengeful, house-sized slug lanced from the heavens and met the Tartarus's base with retina-searing, eardrum-shattering force. Those three inches of plas-glass deformed and popped back. Righteously giddy, Rawlins mopped her raven fringe. "Well. That was good." Dust rolled from the target, but—"Still standing. Captain, reload. Friendlies close. Wait out."

"Ma'am."

Her HUD was giving her fuzz. Everything down there would be dazed by that high-yield kinetic. Yellow indicators now: incoming aircraft, no ID's. Friendlies? PHR. "What are those serene devils doing?" She opened all channels. "Republic craft, this is a live-fire zone. State your purpose." Silence. "Now, please!" The indicators met the base of the Tartarus and vanished. "Curses." Rawlins squinted through the dust—gone, but a hab-sized hole in the ground rendered further speculation unnecessary. PHR ignoring comms was bad. Diplomatic. She touched the new forth star on her lapel—she was ranking officer here. "Pilot, you have control. Land us."

Weirdly distorted static replied, "Comms.... all screwy... Yes ma'am."

As her Phoenix crunched shattered tarmac, Rawlins thumped the hatch release and strode out, a fuming, five-foot-nothing avenger. A dusty squad of grizzled Praetorians met her with salutes. Behind, the hazy bulk of six America class behemoths stood sentinel, crows wheeling about their shoulder batteries. Gazing into the abyss they'd opened, Rawlins didn't flinch at the eruption of railgun fire a block or two north. "Lieutenant, you and your squad will escort me down there."

The lieutenant tossed out a device; it oriented on tiny thrusters and descended, revolving slowly. Eventually, the Lieutenant's control gauntlet beeped. "Damn. That's deep." He handed Rawlins a pair of augmented tac-goggles.

She panned. "A mile? And very cylindrical. But that's impossible. The foundations are a few hundred meters. There's nothing to suggest this—not the scans, not the archives, it's so urbanised, always has been, how—"

"Does it matter?" asked the lieutenant. "It's there." He eyed his squad's Raven. "Fly in?"

"No, lieutenant. We go in quiet. Arrestor packs. Something's not right here." A drunken shimmer of interference washed through her goggles, then their display whipped back. "The Republic might be trying to jam us, but this isn't like... We're wasting time. ONI will want answers."

A Praetorian slammed a backpack-like device onto the tarmac. Rawlins shouldered it, rolled her slender neck, gulped, and nodded to the Lieutenant. He gestured his men forward, stepped to the lip of the underworld, and jumped. After a silent age, the barest hiss of retros echoed up. Rawlins' comm crackled. "Terra firma. Clear. But... this..."

"Lieutenant? Lieutenant?" Rawlins stepped to the edge, swallowed, and leapt. Light vanished. An involuntary screech emptied her lungs. Onrush lashed hair, pummelled eyes, tumbled her. Orient—legs first, using that vanishing pinprick above? Shrill beeps—retros seared her flailing legs, shoulder straps yanked into her, and her boots slammed into smooth rock.

In the green of night vision, the Praetorians were gawping like bloody tourists. Shivering in terror's afterglow and stale, icy air, she soon found herself doing the same. Baroque, crystal-dusted stalactites lined the walls. "Ancient," she breathed. "Scourge didn't... Thousands of years. Thousands." That such a natural cavern could exist here, so near the sea, and—

"Ma'am?" The lieutenant chopped a palm forward: eyes front. The squad crouched, weapons up. Rawlins' heart pounded. Distant glow. A passage. Human shadow there? To Rawlin's left, four of the Republic's sleek Tritons sat idle, lights off. Thought themselves undetected? Or this, whatever it was, was too important to leave anyone? Rawlins drew her father's 9mm UM-93.

As they advanced, sharp breaths rising in clouds, her display suffered rhythmic, acid-trip interrupts. Blessedly, her 'illumination sufficient' indicator blinked on, and the squad stowed their goggles in silent, practiced unison. Through a budding headache, Rawlins focused, irises widening. Ahead, a cold glow backlit a maze of kissing stalactites and stalagmites which almost blocked the cylindrical passage. The squad slipped through.

The lieutenant raised a fist, then silently placed men around the entrance to another space. Darkness opened out ahead, its edges suggested by teal glow on shimmering calcium. But in the chamber's centre, a lean, angular thing stood house-tall, no, hovered. Regular, cylindrical protrusions lined its vertical spine, though it was shrouded by glassy, triangular panels. Bathed in the thing's arctic glow, twenty post-humans gathered, inspecting. A determined resignation there, like acolytes at a temple ruin. Now Rawlins really squinted, the thing was laced with tiny stalagmites. A queasy tingle raced through her, squeezed her brain, pulsed, came back weaker, went. She wobbled. The 'interference' was physical, this close.

"Be still," said a floral breath behind Rawlins' neck. Ice brushed her gooseflesh—a gun's muzzle. The tinny clatters of dropped weapons echoed about the cavern. Frozen, Rawlins glanced left, right—every Praetorian was covered by an operative of the Republic's elite Siren Corps. "Holster your pistol, general. Good. Now turn."

Rawlins studied the Siren. Typical: lustrous hair, flawless, a mannequin from a tactical gear boutique. "What is this? You ignore me, cruise in here unannounced in the middle of a pivotal engagement, then we find—"

"Quieter, competent General Kate Rawlins. Yes, it is our business to know about all of you." The Siren's whisper was sensual, if distinctly sad.

Rawlins caught the lieutenant's eye. He drew down on his sidearm, cocked, fired—missed a ghost. The lieutenant slumped, throat slit, before the thunderous report had finished crashing about. Crushing tingles cascaded through Rawlins' every cell, leaving her dazed, used-up.

"Shit," said the Siren.

In all her disquieting relations with the Republic's creatures, Rawlins had never heard one swear. Other Sirens pressed their weapons into their captives. Rawlins' fists clenched. "You—"

"His fault? Indeed. Come."



A faint thu-thud thu-thud echoed a mile above—her behemoths opening up. Plasma hisses replied. The enemy, nearing, but Rawlins' train of thought got derailed by mind-poking pulses from the thing, matching war's distant tempo.

As they neared, the team around it straightened and stepped back. A ring of containers they'd placed around it sighed, and grey masses climbed from them, questing towards the thing like solid, sentient clouds. One's augmented eyes went glassy. "Nanomachines engaged. Envelope raising will commence in three, two—"

A crush of nausea knuckled Rawlins' skull. "Urgh. What—"

"Response triggered! It's too awake, we—" That subordinate, the closest, never got to finish. His flesh simply wafted away, drawn into the thing like it'd taken a long, deep breath. The bones went next, then his clothes, leaving a wire-veined skeleton of augmentations to sag to the calcified floor. Rawlins gulped back a caustic chunk of vomit. Even the post-humans flinched, but their leader must have given a mental order, as they stilled, bowed their heads, and crossed hands. The nanomachine tendrils reared and dove into the thing like liquid cobras. A sudden cannonball of headache, then that arctic light winked out and it toppled with a metallic clang. A rain of calcium fragments tinkled from it. As the echoes faded, gelatinous, fleshy matter oozed from beneath it, quivered, then sagged into immobility. Solemn silence reigned.

"Sphere's will be done," said the Siren. "Far from ideally."

A grey cloaked man shifted. "Too late again, I fear. Regrettable, that tunnelling was unworkable here."

"Excuse me?" ordered Rawlins. "You got us to target here, to open this up? What was that? Why—"

Grey Cloak glared back. "You Colonials. Your insistent prosecution of this noisy war. We have tried to curb matters, lately through this exasperating alliance, with no other recourse left to us."

"I outrank you, Science Councillor," said Rawlins. "We make it our business to know about you, too. We understand your command structure quite well, and—"

"You understand nothing, girl. And none of you are our equal."

Rawlins stepped forward, incensed. "I'll inform ONI, AHQ, the—"

"No," said the Siren behind her, "you won't".



The year started promisingly. The Tartarus had fallen in December to a precision PHR orbital strike after a mechanical failure aboard UCMS Punisher, the ship previously positioned to do the job. A flight of Tritons had escaped the crater from a previous hit moments before impact, but the UCMA's General Rawlins went MIA, assumed killed in the collapse. After, Scourge forces there lost their cohesion, splintering into smaller armies, some of which fought on until May.

The battles for DC, LA, and New Detroit blazed until late in the year at the cost of millions of lives, thousands of tanks, and countless support vehicles. Despite the clearing debris, the UCMF could never fully exploit its void superiority due to persistent Scourge resistance aboard their remaining orbitals, and regular Shaltari raids. Without full fleet support, North American battles were bloody, attritional affairs, and they were worse everywhere else.

South America fared slightly better than most, given its diminished grid coverage. Buenos Aires, New Sao Paulo, and Bogota were all eventually taken, and gains from the previous year were consolidated. Scourge forces permeated the Andes deep strata mines, always repulsing the far larger Triumvirate forces sent against them. Millions of Scourge remained dug in there by year's end.

Central America was assaulted by a vast, continental pincer movement from the North and South, and PHR and UCM forces ultimately met outside the horribly corrupted sprawl of Tenochtitlan. Given too long to prepare, two million Scourge had twisted the metropolis into a multi-layered fortress. The Triumvirate spent the end of 2674 shelling it, drawing up plans for an attack in January.

Most of Europe's battered, ancient cities were in Triumvirate hands by December, but in Moscow, Kalium's stubborn refusal of Colonial assistance doomed its withered 11th legion to another winter. The Scourge had brought up herds of anti-air behemoths, shielding the region from further mass landings. Moscow had been Kalium's first major failure, and the Kabal would press on to save face at the cost of thousands more conscripts.

Despite successfully holding Hong Kong, much of Asia remained in Scourge hands due to its unequalled grid coverage. The operation to rescue the seven million civilians in Beijing ended bloodily, with over half of them selling their lives in a vengeful charge against their oppressors. The survivors and the tattered rescuers were extracted by late March once it was clear their position was untenable—the Triumvirate's first total retreat in the Battle for Earth.

In Africa though, the PHR under Aurellia Felix single-handedly conquered most of the continent in a textbook, ultra-mobile campaign. The UCMA held Alexandria and New Cairo, but only got as far south as New Thebes, having been pinned by a Scourge counteroffensive from Dubai.

Extract from MF-B-11 report conclusion on Antarctic op, Col. Grant, February 3rd 2674. Classified Level 6—High Council, Supreme Admiral, Naval Theory and MF-B authorised personnel eyes only.

I have no neat conclusion. As detailed, we found the expected number of polar-op tents buried under two feet of snow roughly where expected given time of loss of contact. I conclude the expedition made it to that point intact. Shell cases, weapons, belt buckles, magazines and such were scattered within roughly a two-click radius from the encampment, but no bodies or organic material, and we looked hard. We recovered all logs, recorders, and bodycams, but data was universally corrupted. That's it, really. Nothing like Scourge or Shaltari aftermaths—seen plenty of those. If I had to guess, I'd say a backstab, but why Kalium or the Republic's contingent would pluck off all the damn uniform buttons and leave them in the snow in neat little piles is beyond me. Science Division Alpha has the materiel now. Guess we'll see if they learn anything. I doubt it.

No second Antarctic expedition was approved since Amundsen was now cutoff from enemy resupply after the conquests in South America. The UCM's Office of Naval Intelligence did quietly deploy an MF-B team to the Antarctic peninsula to investigate.

In space, the UCMF, Grand Fleet, Scrapfleet, and the Kalium 1st Armada continued their painstaking campaign to regain the grid, with limited success. The Admiralty had not forgotten that 40% of the Scourge's vast Earth garrison had left the system pre-invasion. None had been sighted since. If undamaged, this would be the most powerful naval force in existence, given the pounding the Triumvirate's fleets had sustained. As such, 30% of available shipping was always stationed near the jump points to affect an early intercept.

Then, the UCM's Fleet Logistical Corps reported increasing losses on resupply runs, mostly to Shaltari or Scourge pirates. Some convoys simply vanished. In response, the UCMF paused its bombardment of Mars' missile halo and diverted more ships from the anti-grid effort to further reinforce the void-lanes to Earth and other Solar bodies. This got results but slowed offensive operations.

By July, the UCM's leaders were receiving irregular intelligence concerning disappearances, anomalous readings, and strange vessels. These occurred within the Solar system, around conquered Cradle Worlds and even near several Colonies. Clandestine activity by the PHR was suspected, so a report was commissioned and presented to the High Council in August. It offered few answers but caused some sleepless nights.

Anomalous Encounters Report, August 19th 2674, Appendix A. Classified Level 6—High Council, Supreme Admiral, Naval Theory and MF-B authorised personnel eyes only.

Final log entries of class-9 Colonial asteroid mining vessel Dimitrov [media corrupted—text recompiled from damaged black box by Specialist Lambant following recovery by Lysander Shadow's Edge. Crew of Shadow's Edge currently isolated at Niccolum Beta blacksite]

August 13th, 2674 (EST)

02:03. [Cap. Houston] Woken by alert claxon. Headed to bridge to relieve First Officer Shipley and receive his report: object approaching at beyond relativistic speed and making small course corrections. Est. time of convergence with us 02:19. Scans return anomalous readings. Assumed instrumentation error. Shall remain on bridge to diagnose issue.

02:45. Erroneous signature decelerating rapidly. Time of convergence receding—currently 02:34. Instrument panels 1-12 passed diagnosis. Still working on fix.

02:59. Object steady now at typical astral body approach speed. Has manoeuvred to avoid multiple asteroids on approach to our cluster. Ruled out instrumentation error—gut judgement call. Sounded general quarters.

03:13. Object holding station 3km from us. Optical scan confirms ship of frigate tonnage. Unknown pattern, likely Shaltari, not responding to hails. Imagery appended. Have assembled crew (19 excluding First Officer who shall remain on bridge) on transverse main gangway, armed. Going to join them.

03:23. [First Officer Shipley] Multiple blips on approach—scouts? Boarders? Who bloody knows. Alien ship otherwise inactive. Our comms node just went dark, so sent sublight SOS to Maganum Prime. Screw protocol. 8+hrs to estimated signal arrival.

03:25. Clanks on hull. Retrieved bridge submachinegun from safe.

03:28. Screams. Crew comms dropping out. 12 still active.

03:36. 4 crew left. They've rallied around lifeboat 2. Going to join them. Sack me in a damn tribunal later. Switching to audio. [Media corrupted. 1st Officer Shipley pants heavily. Multiple expletives omitted for clarity. Partial transcript as follows:] What the actual... are these things? They're... naked... but no... Able got hit and ju... ash... dissolved dammit... just gone... [silence, then Colonial light armour piercing round reports on full-auto, then energy weapon signatures? No database match]. I've seen one... it's... no mouth... and... but they bleed. In pod. Two of us left. Pressing release button – [Audio lost]

03:43. [Ship's computer] WARNING. POD 2 RELEASE INCOMPLETE. COMPLETE RELEASE? SCANNING. CREW VITALS LOST. ENGINE FAILURE. ENGINE FAILURE. CORE DROPPED TO 90% EFFICACY. 70%. 30%. WARNING, CORE—]

03:45. Record ends. Ship's last position 8.272 light hours from Maganum.

STALEMATE

Early in 2675, logistical shipping losses across the UCM's territories became so severe that the UCMF was compelled to send ships from Earth to the Cradle Worlds and Colonies to police the jump points. The Shaltari were responsible for most of these attacks. Grand Admiral Halsey reluctantly issued a statement to Supreme Marshal Zakhaev, his opposite number in the UCMA: the fleet must indefinitely suspend bulk landings as he no longer had the warships to ensure an acceptable survival percentage. The Scourge still held too much of the grid.

The Triumvirate elected to pause its offensives across the globe to consolidate, lick its wounds, and bring in replacements where possible. It held most of South and North America, Europe, and Africa. The Scourge largely held Asia, India, the Middle East, Antarctica, and a sliver of territory in Central America. No regions were free of Scourge taint though, so the armies in place would focus on eradicating all remaining parasite enclaves and armies within their sectors.

The Scourge were quick to capitalise. They entrenched, focused production on defensive armaments, and assimilated every viable host in their breeding hives, even the juveniles, but their missing fleet did not return. What followed were four frustrating, costly years of stalemate.

The UCM had opened their conquered Cradle Worlds of Eden, Elysium, and Shangri-La to resettlement, and vast resources came on stream. Frantic enlargement of the UCM's already unprecedented military caused economic strain at home, body bags still returned by the million, and conscription remained. With the backing of obscenely wealthy defence industrialists, President Bellaque was barely re-elected for a third, constitutionally final, eight-year term in 2676. Thousands of new ships of the latest designs were launched, fresh armoured corps were built, and new legions raised at home and on the liberated Cradle Worlds. Earth's first was the Terran 1st—ex-resistance veterans of North America's victorious East Coasters.

Elsewhere, the Tlalocan moons were in PHR's grip, and Colonial spies on Aaru confirmed a Shaltari conquest of the cavern world, although pockets of Scourge remained. Olympus Prime was riddled with Scourge, and its invasion had been indefinitely postponed in favour of Earth, though the UCMF retained void superiority. No word came from Colonel Helburn's stranded expeditionary force on Asgard, and after so many years they were declared lost. The UCM had no node access to Asgard, and diplomatic overtures to the PHR concerning its status were ignored again, stretching the Triumvirate's uneasy bonds. In these years of stalemate, the partners had increasingly kept their own council, perusing devolved objectives without a grand offensive to unite behind.

Disappearances, phenomena, garbed terror over open channels, secrecy among allies, and unexplained ship losses fuelled a building unease, first among command, then among the enlisted when the rumours could no longer be contained.



Extract from interrogation of Captain G. Hocks, FLC, concerning the FLCS Shoulders of Atlas incident, Sep. 13th, 2678. Ship and surviving crew detained. Classified Level 6—High Council, Supreme Admiral, Naval Theory and MF-B authorised personnel eyes only.

Alright, spooks. This ship, one that was too fast, flashes up on scopes. I sound general quarters. We barely get an hour to tool up. We were too far from a node to transmit or jump. Our escort, the Proudheart, well she just gets sliced in half, right? Saw it with these here baby blues. Must have been more than one ship that hit us. Guess you got a good look at the wreck.

Anyhow, the Shoulders ain't no scrawny merchantman—she's a first-rate superhauler, and these days we go armed after all them losses to the Spikeys. This weird ship comes alongside, cool as you please. She's a cruiser, skinny, all covered in black triangles. We get boarded. Pity for them that we got four hundred vets abroad cruising back for some R&R.

Killed a whole lot of 'em and my crew, mind. Funny thing, and you'd have seen the footage, but these things wore zilch. Bastards were seven foot in bare feet, strong too, silent, but weren't no good at dodging bullets—didn't seem to care overmuch. Anyhow, we won. That ship pulled away, pointed her guns right at us, then sailed off. I swear, if a ship could wink... But those vets, those that didn't get vaporised, well they've seen plenty by now, but loads crapped themselves.

Anyhow, like your frozen corpses? And the live one? Real weird. Each of 'em had this little metal doodad on their skulls, but this one had it shot off. Just stood dumb while its buddies fought on. After, it didn't like nobody touching it, but it weren't thinking. We goaded it into the brigg. Stank, and it looked real sick by the time you guys got to us. Still alive? You ain't gonna tell.

Now I got twenty years loyal service, eight at war, and I wanna know when I get out of here.



Conclusion of autopsy following the FLCS Shoulders of Atlas incident, Prof. R. Ziang, ONI-Medical, Sep. 15th, 2678. Classified Level 6—High Council, Supreme Admiral, Naval Theory and MF-B authorised personnel eyes only.

Subject died soon after admittance, apparently due to microbial and/or viral activity. Bloods showed only rudimentary red cell equivalents—no observable immune system.

Subject was seven feet tall, rangy, humanoid, with no digestive tract, mouth, or reproductive organs. Simple lungs and an oversized heart were the only organs we could determine. Skin was absent, but musculature was extensive and hardened. Bones were present, and despite a lack of joint lubrication and tough tendons, no wear or signs of aging were observed. The skeleton was extensive and bulkier than ours, externally visible in places.

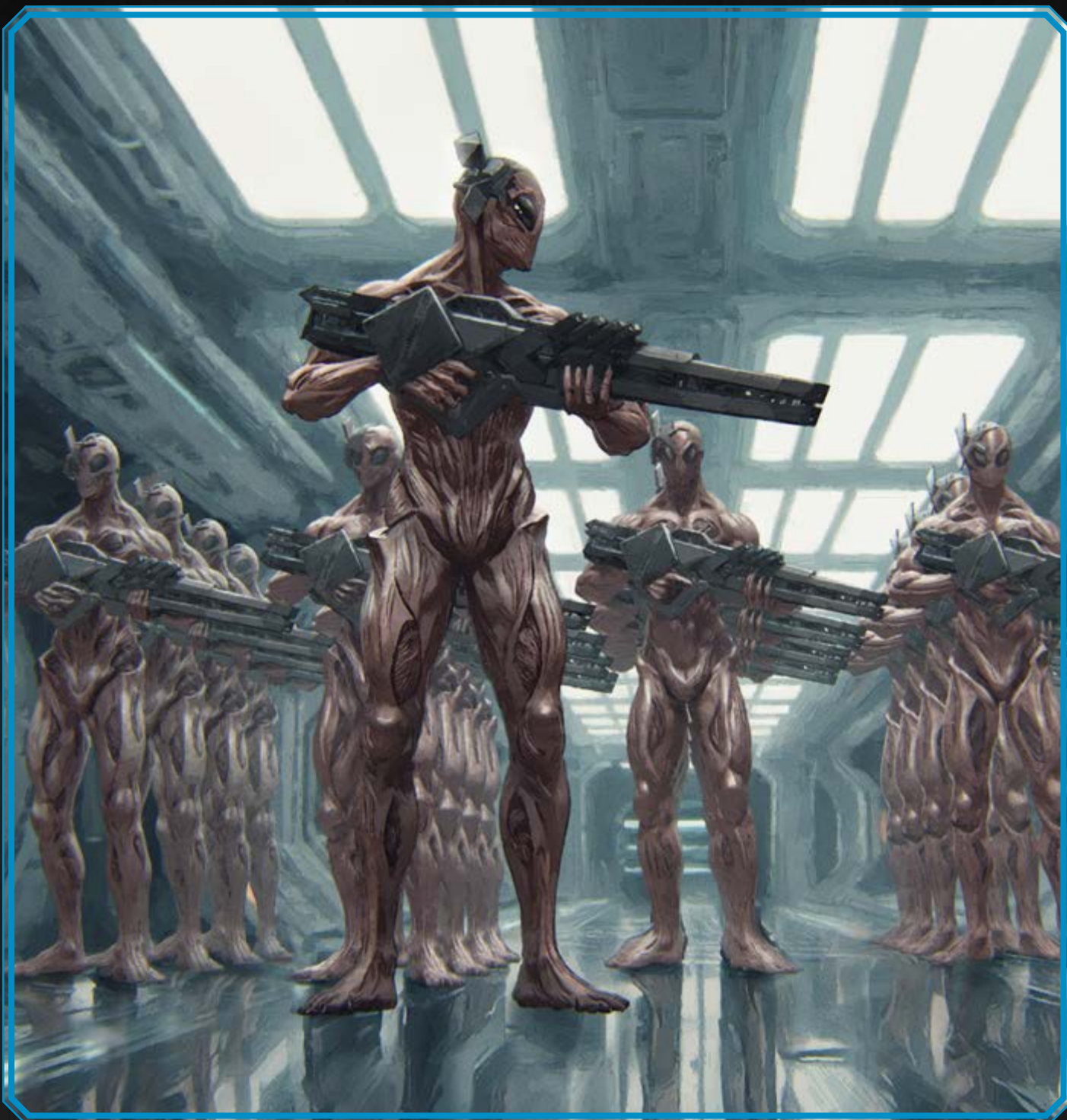
The nervous system was rudimentary, and footage suggests they feel no, or at least very little, pain. I suspect their perception of temperature is crude or absent. Subject's eyes were extremely large, monochromatic, and ovoid, with no iris. A nose was present, and likely affords a limited sense of smell. The brain, and I would use the term loosely, is undersized and basic.

On a cellular level, well, in effect there was no cellular level, not as we understand the term. There appears to be no mechanism for growth or regeneration, and no DNA. No cultures took.

I must conclude that these thing's lifespans could not exceed a week, which seems ridiculous. I cannot determine how they would breed, even. I have seen the combat footage, and they move more like robots. Our specimen became docile due to the loss of its headset. Mechanical are looking at some, but it seems obvious that these things were controlled. A wired probe remained inside the brain of this specimen. I think these are something like combat drones. Metal is good for some things, flesh for others. Even the Republic does not use humanoid robots much—they're complex, expensive, unreliable, and less capable than life. If this is true, what are the minds behind these?

I await Mechanical's conclusions.





Conclusion of alien materiel teardown following the FLCs Shoulders of Atlas incident, Specialist F. Judge, ONI-Mechanical, Sep. 19th, 2678. Classified Level 6—High Council, Supreme Admiral, Naval Theory and MF-B authorised personnel eyes only.

The boarders carried only 'rifles', with no garb or other equipment. Each had a small device drilled into its skull.

Footage proves range exceeds 150m—the longest corridor aboard the Shoulders of Atlas. Fire is point-point, and biologicals puffed into grey smoke when hit, leaving melon-sized cavities. Multiple hits in quick succession vaporised the entire target, sans gear and teeth. Curiously, the wounds were body temperature and not cauterised as one would expect from an energy weapon, so bled profusely. Bulkheads and equipment were largely undamaged.

Sadly, the weapon's internals were cooled slag—a self-destruct, surely. Apparently, they all got hot right after their ship pulled away. Scans confirm known metals and rare elements, but nothing new.

The 'headsets' are just receivers/transmitters, wired permanently into these thing's brains. I've studied plenty of captured Shaltari tech, and these don't come close, but perhaps they don't need to. We don't give basic legionnaires high-level kit.

Sorry I can't give you more. All I can say is, I wouldn't want to get hit by these things.

TRIUMVIRATE'S END

On the last day of another hard year, Kalium's Kabal delivered a communiqué to the High Council and the PHR's Grand Envoy:

The Kabal informs you that Kalium is withdrawing from the Triumvirate Accord, as per its terms, with immediate effect.

Our new Supreme Leader, General Solarion, has declared our primary objective achieved. Oceans of Kalium blood has been spent in Earth's conquest, and we will retain all territories we paid for. Colonial or Republican citizens are welcome to visit, with appropriate papers.

It has been and honour to fight with you in this righteous struggle, and we hope you will treat us as equal neighbours in the coming peace.

This, naturally, incensed the High Council. The war was not won and carving up Earth had never been tabled. Kalium was a distasteful throwback, not an equal. This was also the first they had heard of a new Supreme Leader—spies would report the previous incumbent had been assassinated with radioactive caviar. Death was, apparently, the means of succession in Kalium. The Kabal had tired of sending its conscripts to die under the auspices of the UCM.

The day of its declaration, Kalium began fortifying its possessions of Earth, and border tensions immediately arose. None were permitted entry. For the first time since the 24th century, Earth was subject to multiple, wary governments. AHQ began contingency planning for the worst.

Perhaps due to Kalium's departure, PHR forces began pulling out of the Solar system. Officially they remained in alliance, but cooperation and free communication were long dead. The Republic's vigour in perusing its ground objectives had faded years ago, and most of their operations since had been careful affairs, preserving post-human lives. However, Aurelia Felix, the conqueror of Africa, still freely committed her forces against the worst Scourge redoubts.





FEBRUARY 7TH, 2679

REVELATION

On the morning of February 7th, Earth Eastern Standard, the 339th Taskforce UCMF, Battlefleet Eden, began a routine anti-piracy interdiction patrol near Eden Prime's main jump point. At 09:00hrs, the flagship's long-range scanners detected multiple blips approaching at beyond relativistic speeds. By 13:00hrs, the entire taskforce, including nine capital ships, was wreckage. Minutes later, an unencrypted message was broadcast on general frequencies across most Colonial systems:

We now have our measure of you. You are indeed sufficient. Your response though, thus far, has been disappointing. We see you are distracted by squabbles with fellow, less interesting flesh sentients, so this communique should redress matters.

We are your extinction, at our leisure. During this epoch, we will enjoy your suffering, your endings, and, most especially, the fight we think you will give us.

We are Bioficers. We endure. We experience. And we are coming for you.

Appended was garbled footage of the taskforce's annihilation interlaced with more personal, horrific content of boarding actions. The aggressors featured prominently—a menagerie of ghastly, expressionless bioforms, and not just humanoid ones. Spider things, snake creatures, winged monsters, many-eyed, eyeless, big, small, armed, unarmed, and all murderous.

If the intention had been to break the UCM through panic, it failed. It had lived under the shadow of a terrible enemy for centuries, and its people were hardened to loss. When the Scourge had invaded, all seven Cradle Worlds and Earth had been taken in days of sheer apocalypse. One taskforce was nothing. Morale, though, sunk even further.

SCHISM, A NEW WAR

Bioficer attacks grew from concealable rarities to a trickle of larger incidents. The UCMF began learning about this foe. With a watch beyond the outer markers in place, a typical attack pattern appeared: traveling fast, then slow to combat speeds, and undetectable more than a few hours from their target—possible cloaking, or the effect of physics-breaking speed, but beyond current theoretical models. This gave less warning than the usual eight or so hours from a jump point to orbit, but how long they took to travel between systems was unknown—certainly longer than instant foldspace jumps. Why this advanced race couldn't or wouldn't jump was unknown.

Early engagements saw some victories—the interlopers could be beaten. Estimates placed their advancement above the Scourge and below the Shaltari, although they used many potent technologies unique to them. The theory that their boarding troops were remotes gathered credence, but attempts to infiltrate and investigate their 'leadership caste' failed.

The PHR pullout gathered pace, and on March 1st, Aurelia Felix requested an in-person audience with the High Council. All expected a formal withdrawal from the alliance. She landed on Aurum on March 2nd and progressed under guard to the council chamber.

A statuesque, raven-haired figure of indeterminate age, severe confidence, and the record to back that confidence, Aurelia Felix commanded the room.

Ladies and gentlemen of the High Council, thank you for accepting me. Events are moving, so I shall be brief. The Republic has concealed much, too much, from you. Thanks to The Sphere, we have always known of these 'Bioficers'. I cannot blame you for distaining our advice not to launch your reconquest, and I believe we failed unconscionably in our silence afterwards. The feeling that you would never listen prevailed, that the Scourge should be confronted on your terms before Shaltari drew them to you, and that war would harden us all against the inevitable.

So, the Bioficers. Think of the galaxy as a savanna. The Shaltari are the birds. The Scourge are the termites. You are the lions. They are the trophy hunters. You have roared exceedingly, and hunters are uninterested in cubs.

In these nine years of war, our primary objective was to silence their listening beacons. They place these wherever adversaries worth their attentions might evolve. They are buried deep and dimensionally cloaked. Only we can detect them. Incidentally, we chose the Tlalocan system as our forward base since it may have been within the Bioficer's origin region. We are investigating and disabling all technologies excavated. We have slowed their interest considerably, but insufficiently.

The Scourge are less interesting to them. The parasites have emotions, rage especially, but their fears and sufferings are dulled by their racial commitments. The Shaltari avoid them. This is why they have no homeworlds—yes, the Shaltari are spaceborne. Their adventure on Aaru is led by romantics—that was their birth rock. They will draw the Bioficer's eyes. The Shaltari do fear, pathologically.

What are they? The Sphere surmises they were weapons that outlasted their masters. They are code, but individuals. Each sentience was generated eons ago, cannot be replicated, and is beyond our comprehension. Some are quite limited, like those that pilot their vehicles, others are towering intellects. Each exists in a distinct, physical space, but can be transferred, like when a ship or vehicle is destroyed. Each transfer introduces data corruptions. Simply, they become less capable and less sane each time. They were built to enjoy war. By now, they are twisted things.

They are master fleshbuilders. They cannot synthesise complex, sentient, or lasting structures, but biology is their clay. They can vaporise it, ingest it, and shape it. The drones you have fought can be woven in minutes and are disposable. Their bioforms are built for specific tasks, as needed, and might be any shape your nightmares can conjure.

Their technology is apparently painstaking to build, and their spacefaring is glacial—we suspect foldspace jumps degrade their code. Losses will slow them, but they are in no rush. They have no grand strategy. Time is irrelevant to them. They want us to resist, and we have no choice but to. We are their playthings until they annihilate us. That may take years, decades, or lifetimes.

If we unite, hold firm, and advance sufficiently, there is hope. That is my belief. The Sphere thinks differently, it seems. It suggests we return home 'to rearm', or that's what the political leadership says. I suspect they are trying to avoid panic. The Sphere was always meant to advise, not order, but many follow it blindly now, religiously, even. They call me a heretic—that troubles me. My command will remain engaged. I am a soldier, a woman of honour, and we haven't fought for Earth only to abandon it when things get tough. Others who feel likewise may be joining me in the coming days.

The Bioficer attacks so far were raindrops. The Scourge are far from beaten, and we must exterminate them before the monsoon hits. Prepare. Good hunting. That is all.



MARCH 13TH, 2679, 24692 LOCAL TIME, PEARLESCENT, CAERULEUM PRIME, POST HUMAN REPUBLIC.

I am General Kate Elaine Rawlins. I am still a soldier of the Colonies. But I am so much more now. As I wake, this is my mantra. I can determine with clarity that my brain is functioning well this morning. My body remains averagely performant, slight, if apparently pleasing, but my first elective augmentations feel excellent today, and are interfaced flawlessly. And, yes, my apartment's menial familiars are already active, bless them.

I have been here, as something of a pseudo-prisoner, for five years, three months, four days, two hours, nineteen minutes, and eleven seconds by the old reckoning. I replay yesterday's interactions with my fellow interned and feel those frustrations and guilt again. They had valid points, some despise me now, and I should have described this better, but how? I am unusual in accepting The Binding. It frightens them, as it did me, but I am happy with my choice. I am unquestionably improved, and if I pass naturalisation, I may join this society. I stem the endorphins this would otherwise release, lest they cloud my reasoning today.

It is artful here, calm, clean, civilised, exciting, and alive with possibility. Already, other, fascinating post-human minds within this tower brush mine, but not invasively. They can't commune unless I want them

to, and I do not, I am in bed, but the suggestion of their presence and kinship warms me.

I rise and will my window's opacity away. Good—my aptitude is improving. Sunlight feels more beautiful on me than it used to. The expanding, glossy, creamy skyline dazzles me. A lot of ships in the sky today. Ninety-seven more. These eyes—sublime. My minders remain silent on the subject, but the Grand Fleet is mustering—why? My clumsy poking into their minds suggests they do not know either. Certainly, a discord ferments among the real citizens here. And they won't help me understand. I should like to. Utopias must be maintained, like flowerbeds.

I make it to the bathroom, and a silence expunges me. I gasp, stagger, grab the handrail. I can't fill that silence with new thoughts, but a voice that isn't mine does. "Citizens, we are under attack. This is not a drill. A Scourge fleet has arrived at the outer marker. It is substantial, but our fleet is prepared, thank The Sphere. All military personnel, report to battle stations. Civilians, please follow your local war protocols. Guests, remain in your assigned areas and await guidance. Sphere be with you all."